THE ELON GAZETTE

Weekday briefing on what Elon Musk is saying and doing

MONDAY, OCTOBER 26, 2026

THE MORNING PICTURE

Starlink's terms, and a $40 billion lease

Elon Musk spent the weekend defending SpaceX's decision to restrict how Ukraine's military uses Starlink. "Ukraine military violated Starlink terms of service and used it for offensive drone strikes to kill people. That loophole was closed last week," he posted at 2:38 p.m. EDT on Saturday, adding that "SpaceX has done more to defend Ukraine than any private company on Earth BY FAR." A Ukrainian adviser disputed the account on Sunday, and Ukraine's Defense Ministry said Saturday that Starlink speeds had been restored on fast-moving equipment, CNBC reported.

On Monday, SpaceX disclosed a binding commitment for a roughly $40 billion lease to finance graphics processing units (GPUs), the chips that train and run artificial intelligence (AI) systems. The company's 8-K filing names an Apollo-managed entity as the lessor. Musk had previewed it Sunday and used it to argue that lenders are now rationing money for companies without revenue beyond AI data centers.

I · STARLINK & UKRAINE

"A civilian operation"

Musk says Starlink cannot be used for offensive strikes. Ukrainian officials say limits on the civilian service already made that impossible.

Oct. 14	400 km/h	70–90 km/h
when Ukrainian officials say speed limits began disrupting Starshield drones	speed above which Ukraine says service was restored Saturday	cap on civilian Starlink, per a Ukrainian adviser

The dispute began earlier this month. Ukrainian officials said that since October 14, speed limits on Starshield, the US government's military version of the network, had disrupted drones flying faster than about 100 mph. On Saturday, Ukraine's Defense Ministry said speeds had been restored on equipment moving above 400 km/h, CNBC reported. Musk's answer, in a post replying to a supporter, drew a line between the two systems: "Starshield, a different system, is controlled by the US government. What they decide to do is up to them."

ON THE WIRE

Starlink growth. Musk says Starlink V3 will have about 100 times the bandwidth of V2, in a post replying to a note on 13.6 million subscribers.



A Support Forces of Ukraine soldier installs a Starlink terminal, July 21, 2022.
PHOTO: SUPPORT FORCES OF UKRAINE COMMAND / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS · CC BY 4.0

Musk repeated the point through the evening. At 8:33 p.m. EDT on Saturday he answered journalist Jamie Dupree, who had noted that members of both parties say the Pentagon must find other partners than SpaceX: "Starlink's terms have remained consistent as a civilian system, not a means of killing.

Violation of those terms will result in end of service." At 9:10 p.m. he told the account zerohedge: "We simply enforced our terms of service when they were bypassed. There has been no change to our terms of service."

At 2:12 a.m. EDT on Sunday, replying to a post about Russia's 2021 anti-satellite missile test, Musk gave a reason for the rule. Starlink "can be used for infrastructure that is military, but it cannot be used for unequivocally offensive strikes that make it fair game to be struck back," he wrote. An adversary destroying Starlink satellites, he added, "would create a domino effect of destruction that would generate a vast field of debris making space unusable." At 10:02 a.m. he pointed to a post by President Volodymyr Zelenskyy that he said described using Starlink for offensive drone strikes, which "has always been against Starlink's terms of service."

QUICK HIT

The other side. Serhii Beskrestnov, a defense technology adviser to Zelenskyy, said the civilian system "does not function over the territory of Russia" and has carried a 70–90 km/h speed limit for months, so medium- and deep-range strikes with it are "PHYSICALLY IMPOSSIBLE," according to the Associated Press. The Washington Post also covered the exchange.

Musk also described the stakes as he sees them. "Starlink remains critical to the defense of Ukraine, as it is the only system that cannot be jammed or blown up, at least for now," he wrote on Saturday. "Were Starlink to be turned off, the Ukrainian front line would collapse immediately. This is NOT a threat, it is simply a statement of fact." The line echoes a 2023 episode in which SpaceX said it had blocked Ukraine from using Starlink with military drones.

II · SPACEX

All 33 engines, then easyJet

The Flight 15 booster fired for its full duration, Musk put a number on Raptor 4, and easyJet picked Starlink as Aer Lingus finished its rollout.

33	300 tons	2027
engines fired in Booster 22's static fire	Musk's sea-level thrust target for Raptor 4	easyJet begins Starlink installation, first half

SpaceX posted at 3:49 p.m. EDT on Sunday: "Full duration 33-engine static fire for the Super Heavy booster preparing for Flight 15." Musk reposted it at 8:26 p.m. The booster is Booster 22 on Pad 2 at Starbase, Texas, and the test lit all engines at 9:22 a.m. EDT, Spaceflight News reported. No launch date has been announced; aviation data point to no earlier than November 8, the same report says. On the October 20 earnings webcast, Musk said Flight 15 would try to catch both the booster and the ship, The Space Road noted.



A Super Heavy booster beside the launch tower at Starbase, Texas, during Starship's fifth flight test on Oct. 13, 2024.

PHOTO: STEVE JURVETSON / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS · CC BY 2.0 (CROPPED)

On Monday at 9:58 a.m. EDT, replying to a post comparing rocket engines, Musk wrote: "Raptor 4 will be 300 tons of thrust at sea level and hopefully about the same mass." Spaceflight News puts the current Raptor 3 at 250 tonnes-force, up from 230.

At 9:16 a.m. EDT on Monday Musk wrote "Starlink coming to EasyJet." The British airline's announcement says installation on its A320, A320neo and A321neo aircraft starts in the first half of 2027 and finishes in early 2028. Pricing was not disclosed. Earlier this year the airline had said the "economics aren't quite working for us," AeroTime reported, and Apollo agreed in August to buy easyJet for £5.7 billion.

QUICK HIT

Aer Lingus. The Irish airline has finished installing free Starlink Wi-Fi on its long-haul fleet, 12 Airbus A330s and 14 A321s, One Mile at a Time reported. Short-haul aircraft are next. Musk called it "a cunning move by Aer Lingus."

Replying Saturday at 3:20 p.m. EDT to a post saying Starlink has 13.6 million subscribers, Musk wrote that "Starlink V3, which only just started launching, will have ~100 times more bandwidth than the current V2 system." At 2:43 p.m. he quote-posted a clip of Bolivian President Rodrigo Paz describing about 4,700 Starlink antennas going to schools nationwide, with the words "Starlink in Bolivia!" He also reposted a Falcon 9 launch of 27 more Starlink satellites from California.

QUICK HIT

Back to the Moon. At 12:02 a.m. EDT on Sunday Musk quote-posted the NASA briefing from Friday with "Back to the Moon." NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman said Artemis III will send four astronauts to low Earth orbit in 2027 to test systems for lunar landings, with the first landing on Artemis IV in 2028.

III · AI & COMPUTE

"Stranded compute"

As SpaceX disclosed a $40 billion GPU lease, Musk predicted trouble for smaller AI cloud providers and defended the economics of AI demand.

$40B	1H 2027	$35–40B
aggregate payments under the Apollo-managed lease	when lease schedules begin, on GPU delivery	fourth-quarter capital spending SpaceX expects

SpaceX's 8-K says the company signed a binding commitment letter on October 24 for a master finance lease with an Apollo-managed entity covering GPU equipment. Aggregate principal payments come to about $40 billion over terms of roughly five years, rent is paid quarterly in advance, and the deal is expected to close before year-end. Lease schedules begin in the first half of 2027 as chips are delivered. SpaceX's press release says the chips are Nvidia's Vera Rubin generation, with Apollo and Goldman Sachs leading and funds managed by BlackRock, Goldman Sachs Asset Management and accounts advised by KKR as anchor investors.

Musk had discussed it on Sunday. Replying to investor Chamath Palihapitiya at 3:11 p.m. EDT, he wrote that "debt markets have almost entirely shut off access to money for any company that doesn't have substantial revenue independent of AI data centers." He added: "SpaceX closed $40B of debt for GPUs, but we're investment grade and have Starlink & launch." Replying to Sawyer Merritt at 3:50 p.m., he said it is "primarily callable debt for GPU purchases that will arrive in Q1 and Q2. Not a major factor this quarter." Capital spending in the fourth quarter is expected at $35 billion to $40 billion, Chief Financial Officer Bret Johnsen said, Reuters reported.

The financing follows a quarter in which SpaceX reported revenue of $14.58 billion, up 161% from a year earlier, including $7.56 billion from AI, Reuters reported.

QUICK HIT

No acquisitions. Musk wrote at 5:01 p.m. EDT on Sunday: "SpaceX is not buying any neoclouds. Pointless." Neoclouds are newer companies that rent out GPUs. Reuters said he predicted a shakeout among them.

On demand, Musk wrote Saturday at 12:49 p.m. that "agentic demand is growing faster than I've ever seen anything grow." At 9:32 p.m. he told Yuchen Jin, "I think we're going to see a lot of stranded compute in partially complete data centers." On Sunday at 11:43 a.m. he dismissed one accounting question: "Accounting depreciation is irrelevant," he wrote. "Delivering on projected cash flow is what matters."

Musk also described how many things must work at once to turn on a large AI computer. On Saturday at 9:29 p.m. he quote-posted a list of limits on supercomputer buildouts, among them power, with the comment: "If anything is missing, however seemingly trivial, the compute doesn't work."

At 11:58 p.m. on Saturday he quote-posted a chart from the venture firm Andreessen Horowitz showing GPUs renting ahead of a standard six-year depreciation schedule: H200 chips at 143% above it, B200 at 111%, A100 at 9%. His comment: "How many super smart and dedicated people do you want to hire? And they keep getting better."

ON THE WIRE

Lease timing. SpaceX's 8-K says the GPU lease is expected to close before year-end, with schedules starting in the first half of 2027.

IV · TESLA

"Houston, we have liftoff"

Tesla widened its Robotaxi zone in Houston, and the new map looks like a rocket.

9:38 a.m.	225,964
EDT Monday, when @robotaxi announced the larger zone	driverless miles in Houston, Jan. 22–Oct. 18

The Robotaxi account posted at 9:38 a.m. EDT on Monday: "Houston, we have liftoff. Bigger service area now live." TeslaNorth said the old zone, a small patch of northwest Houston near Cypress, is now the "nose" of a Starship-shaped map that runs southeast through downtown toward Bellaire and the edge of Pasadena. Musk quote-posted it at 9:45 a.m. with "I swear it's just a coincidence." Tesla did not give an area for the new zone or say whether hours changed.

ON THE WIRE

Austin and Dallas. The same safety report counts 2,118,015 driverless miles in Austin and 608,130 in Dallas, TeslaNorth reported.



A Tesla Cybercab on Harrison Street in San Francisco on June 12, 2026.
PHOTO: 9YZ / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS · CC BY 4.0 (CROPPED)

The previous zone covered about 25 square miles, Teslarati reported, and Houston launched without safety monitors on April 18. TeslaNorth's tally of Tesla's first Robotaxi Safety Report counts 225,964 driverless miles in Houston between January 22 and October 18, against 2,118,015 in Austin and 608,130 in Dallas. Pulling downtown into the zone could help Houston narrow that gap. Drive Tesla Canada covered the expansion as well. Last week Tesla said Robotaxi service will run until 2 a.m. soon, with 24-hour rides by year-end.

Friday at 1:09 p.m. EDT, replying to a user, Musk wrote: "Tesla ramping up Megapack production rapidly to meet increasing demand."

QUICK HIT

Roadster on view. Musk quote-posted Tesla North America's note that the Roadster is on display at the Petersen Automotive Museum in Los Angeles from October 24 through 27, with the words "Roadster at Petersen."

V · X & GROK

Grok Bot learns to make calls

Musk promoted Grok Bot's new calling feature, and X Money is adding a one-dollar gesture.

At 10:35 a.m. EDT on Sunday, Musk quote-posted a user's notes on Grok Bot version 0.77 with a summary of its biggest feature: "Grok @Bot can now call someone or a business for you, make a request on your behalf, take notes on the response and send you a note summarizing the conversation!" The post quoted notes listing calls with live transcripts, Messages setup on Mac, joining a Tailscale network, a Payments screen and sharing emails.

On Friday evening he also amplified the @bot announcement that the assistant can save logins, cards and contact details in a vault. At 11:17 a.m. Sunday he added: "The best way to use Grok @Bot is assume you are hiring a super competent employee." Replying to Larry Goldberg at 10:55 a.m., who suggested that the assistant join Zoom or Teams calls for him, he wrote "This might be possible." At 4:35 p.m., replying to Goldberg again, he asked: "Log in to the car with your main Grok Bot?"

The same notes describe calling in practical terms: the assistant dials, holds, presses keys and shows a live transcript while the call is in progress.

QUICK HIT

$1 on a long press. At 10:39 p.m. EDT on Saturday Musk wrote that X is adding long press on the like button to send someone $1 through X Money.

On Saturday at 1:45 a.m. he quote-posted the first episode of Odyssey, a series made with Grok Imagine in partnership with Wonder Studios and director Dev Walker.

Takeaways

1. Musk says Ukraine's military broke Starlink's terms; a Ukrainian adviser disputes it.
2. SpaceX committed to a roughly $40 billion GPU lease led by Apollo.
3. Starship's Flight 15 booster completed a 33-engine static fire.
4. easyJet will install Starlink starting in the first half of 2027.
5. Tesla widened Robotaxi service in Houston; Grok Bot can now make calls.

Sources

Posts by @elonmusk, @SpaceX, @robotaxi, @bot, @chamath, @SawyerMerritt, @a16z, @jamiedupree, @zerohedge, @TeslaLarry, @Yuchenj_UW, @aaronburnett, @WOLF_Financial, @firesidealpha, @tesla_na, @alexmichael and @imagine.

SpaceX 8-K (SEC) · SpaceX · CNBC · Associated Press · The Washington Post · Reuters (via Investing.com) · Ars Technica · Spaceflight News · The Space Road · easyJet · AeroTime · Air Data News · One Mile at a Time · NASA · TeslaNorth · Teslarati · Drive Tesla Canada · Photos: Wikimedia Commons (Support Forces of Ukraine Command, CC BY 4.0; Steve Jurvetson, CC BY 2.0)

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